Home Care, Assisted Living, Memory Care: The Words You'll Hear and What to Write Down About Each

Seventeen terms in one plain line each, and what to jot down when one comes up.

Home care, assisted living, memory care, skilled nursing. Everyone uses the words as if you already knew the difference. These are the ones you're most likely to hear while you're planning ahead, each with one plain line taken from a public source and a note of what to write down. Where no source defines a word, the sheet says so.

The definitions are for following the conversation. They aren't for deciding which kind of care Mom needs, or what she might qualify for.

Everyday life

Long-term care

A range of services and supports a person may need to meet personal care needs. Most of it is not medical care but help with the basic personal tasks of everyday life. [1]

WRITE DOWN Any help Mom already gets that fits this description.

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to or from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which ones she does on her own today, and which with a hand.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

Everyday tasks such as housework, managing money, taking medication, preparing meals, shopping, using the telephone and caring for pets. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now.

Care preferences

What Mom says she would want if she ever needed more help. The Administration for Community Living notes that most people prefer to remain in their homes for as long as possible; her own answer is the one to record. [2]

WRITE DOWN Her answers in her own words, with the date.

Kinds of care

Family caregiving

Care at home from unpaid family members and friends. Most long-term care is provided at home. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who helps Mom now, with what, and since when.

Home care

Care that comes to the home, from a nurse, a home health or home care aide, or a therapist. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether she has ever had any, and what you'd ask a local agency about what it provides.

Adult day program

A community service. The Administration for Community Living lists adult day care service centers among the supports that can add to the care given at home. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether there is one near Mom, and what you'd want to ask it.

Assisted living

Housing and services for people who need some help with daily care, such as dressing, bathing, taking medicines and cleaning, but who do not need the medical care that a nursing home provides. [3]

WRITE DOWN The places near Mom that you know of, and your questions for them.

Memory care

A term you may hear from providers. None of the public sources listed here defines it. MedlinePlus does note that assisted living residents include people with Alzheimer's or other types of dementia. [3]

WRITE DOWN What each provider who uses the term says it includes.

Nursing home

A facility for people who usually need around-the-clock care. Nursing homes provide the most comprehensive range of services, including nursing care. [4] [2]

WRITE DOWN Nothing to decide. Note any questions the word raises for you.

Skilled care (skilled nursing)

Nursing and therapy care that can only be safely and effectively performed by, or under the supervision of, professionals or technical personnel. [5]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom gets any now, and from whom.

Custodial care

Another name for long-term care: help with activities of daily living, like bathing, dressing or eating. Also called long-term services and supports. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who used the word, so you can ask what they meant by it.

Hospice and palliative care

In hospice care the focus is on comfort, not on curing an illness, and care is generally given in the home. Medicare's hospice booklet describes palliative care as the part of hospice that focuses on quality of life. [6]

WRITE DOWN Anything Mom has said about what matters most to her, in her own words.

Paying for care

Medicare (and long-term care)

Medicare generally doesn't cover long-term care in a nursing home, and it does not pay for non-skilled help with activities of daily living. [7] [8]

WRITE DOWN Which kind of Medicare coverage Mom has, and where her card is kept.

Medicaid

A joint federal and state program that helps some people pay for health care, including long-term care in nursing homes and at home. Eligibility rules and covered services vary from state to state. [9]

WRITE DOWN Your questions about it, for your Medicaid planner. Whether Mom might qualify isn't something to work out from a sheet like this.

Long-term care insurance

Insurance that can help pay for many types of long-term care, both skilled and non-skilled. Policies vary widely. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has a policy, and where it is. What it covers is a question for the insurance company.

Private pay

Paying for care out of pocket. [7]

WRITE DOWN Nothing yet. What care might cost is a question for the providers near Mom, later on.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't tell you which of them apply to Mom, when any kind of care becomes the right one, or what any program would cover or require. It isn't medical, legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know what the words mean and what to jot down about each. The care interview asks about the same areas in plain language, one at a time, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Where Can You Receive Care?
3. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Assisted Living: MedlinePlus
4. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Nursing Home Coverage

5. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), SNF Care Coverage
6. Medicare (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), Medicare Hospice Benefits
7. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?
8. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Planning Ahead After Age 65
9. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid

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